

A.O.F.G. – Description of Officer Positions

The following positions apply to the officers within the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners.

Lodge	Grand Lodge	United Council	Position
Worthy Master	Most Worthy Grand Master	Chairman	Elected
Emissary Master	Most Worthy Emissary Master	Vice-Chairman	Elected
Secretary	Most Worthy Secretary	Secretary-General	Elected
Rentmaster	Most Worthy Rentmaster	Treasurer	Elected
Instruction Master	Most Worthy Instruction Master	Archivist	Elected
Chaplain	Right Worthy Chaplain	Parliamentarian	Appointed
Keyholder	Right Worthy Keyholder	Master-at-Arms	Appointed
Gatekeeper	Right Worthy Gatekeeper	Marshal	Appointed

- United Council Director (officer) positions are elected for a 3-year term
- Grand Lodge Officer positions are elected or appointed for a 3-year term
- Lodge Officer positions are elected or appointed for a 2-year term

Details are defined in the Lodge, Grand Lodge and United Council bylaws

Worthy Master

- **Historical Significance:** The Worthy Master serves as the head and guiding figure of the Lodge / Grand Lodge, much like a president or chairperson. This role represents wisdom, leadership, and the embodiment of the group's principles.

Responsibilities:

- Presides over ceremonies and meetings, maintaining order, peace, and harmony.

- Leads the organization with a focus on the values of love, wisdom, harmony, and truth.
- Opens and closes ceremonies, setting the tone for the group's metaphorical gardening work.
- Encourages members to contribute to the common good and uphold the group's principles.

Symbolism: Represents the central figure of guidance, embodying the Supreme Gardener who nurtures creation. They sit at the eastern table, symbolizing the rising light of leadership and wisdom.

Emissary Master

- **Historical Significance:** The Emissary Master would serve as the Lodge / Grand Lodge's representative to external groups or lodges. They would foster relationships, manage correspondence, and act as an ambassador for the Lodge's mission and values.
 - **Responsibilities:**
 - Represents the lodge to external groups, maintaining relationships with other lodges and societies.
 - Evaluates and instructs seekers, assessing their readiness for membership.
 - Collaborates with the Key Holder and Gate Keeper to guide initiates into the lodge.
 - **Symbolism:** Represents the bridge between the inner and outer worlds, facilitating the growth of the lodge's community and ideals.
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Instruction Master

- **Historical Significance:** This role is central to the educational and initiatory aspects of the organization. The Instruction Brother would guide new members through their initiation and provide ongoing learning opportunities to existing members.
- **Responsibilities:**
 - Guides and mentors new members (seekers) during their initiation, helping them understand Free Gardening principles.

- Ensures seekers are protected from misinformation or overwhelming knowledge during the initiation process.
 - Functions as the "inner psychopomp," navigating between the inner Paradise Garden and the outer lodge.
 - **Symbolism:** Protects and nurtures the spiritual growth of members, representing love and preservation as the foundation of initiation.
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Secretary

The **Secretary** is a critical officer in any fraternal organization or lodge, including groups like the Free Gardeners. This role ensures the administrative and operational aspects of the lodge run smoothly. The Secretary is often seen as the organizational backbone, keeping everything in order and maintaining clear communication within the group.

- **Responsibilities:**
 - Records minutes of meetings and ceremonies, ensuring accurate documentation.
 - Assists in distributing ceremonial vestments during certain degrees (e.g., aprons in the first and third degrees).
 - Reads the ancient customs and coordinates administrative tasks, such as correspondence and record-keeping.
- **Symbolism:** Acts as the organizational thread, ensuring the continuity and order of the lodge's operations. Symbolized by the blood-red rose during ceremonies, representing the love that unites members.
- **Administrative Duties:**
 - Records and maintains minutes during meetings, ensuring accurate documentation of discussions, decisions, and actions.
 - Prepares meeting agendas in collaboration with the Worthy Master and other officers.

- Manages correspondence, including invitations, announcements, and external communication.
- Oversees record-keeping for membership lists, lodge history, and other essential documents.
- **Membership Management:**
 - Keeps track of member details, including contact information and dues status.
 - Ensures new members are formally registered and that initiation or onboarding processes are recorded.
- **Liaison Role:**
 - Acts as the primary point of contact between the lodge and external organizations, working alongside the Emissary Master.
 - Disseminates information to members, such as meeting dates, special events, or changes in lodge operations.

Support Role:

- Assists other officers with their duties by providing documentation or logistical support.
- Ensures that the lodge operates in accordance with its rules and regulations by maintaining a clear understanding of its constitution or bylaws.

Chaplain

- **Historical Significance:** The Chaplain serves as the spiritual guide or moral compass of the lodge. This role emphasizes nurturing the inner values and ethical conduct of the members.
- **Responsibilities:**
 - Provides spiritual and moral guidance during ceremonies, often reciting key scriptural or symbolic passages.
 - Reads the ancient customs and leads

- invocations or meditations to align members with the values of Free Gardening.
- Reinforces the virtues of love, wisdom, harmony, and truth.
 - **Symbolism:** Embodies the spiritual soil from which all members draw inspiration and strength, connecting the group to the Supreme Gardener.
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Rent Master

- **Historical Significance:** In the context of organizations like the Free Gardeners, the Rent Master would likely be responsible for managing the financial or material contributions (such as dues or rents) from members. The term "rent" could symbolically represent the resources required to maintain the "garden" or lodge.
- **Responsibilities:**
 - Collects contributions from members during ceremonies (e.g., during White Gardening).
 - Ensures the financial health of the lodge and supports its charitable endeavours.
- **Symbolism:** Steward of the lodge's resources, embodying trust and the collective responsibility of tending the garden

Keyholder

- **Responsibilities:**
 - Guards the inner gate, controlling access to the lodge and assisting the Gate Keeper.
 - Organizes and directs the arrangement of attendees during ceremonies.
 - Works closely with the Emissary Master and Gate Keeper to ensure proper entry and distribution of roles.

- **Symbolism:** Represents the trusted steward of the lodge's sacred space, ensuring the inner garden remains undisturbed and protected.
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Gatekeeper

- **Responsibilities:**
 - Guards the outer gate, facilitating the transition between the external world and the lodge.
 - Directs members and guests as they enter or leave the garden, ensuring ceremony etiquette.
 - Functions as the "outer psychopomp," guiding seekers toward enlightenment.
- **Symbolism:** Represents the boundary between the material and spiritual realms, ensuring only those ready for the inner journey are admitted.